

The Great Depression

Trace how one economic collapse sent shockwaves through four systems — political, economic, social-cultural, and geographic-environmental — and decide which change lasted longest.

? Historical challenge

The 1929 crash did more than empty bank accounts. Its shockwaves reshaped American politics, the economy, society and culture, and even the land itself. Follow the event outward through four systems, weigh who benefited and who bore the costs, and decide which change left the deepest mark.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

The Great Depression – Federal Reserve History

SECONDARY SOURCE

How bank failures and a shrinking money supply deepened the collapse.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What role did bank failures and the Federal Reserve play?
- How does this source explain the depth of the Depression?

SOURCES 2

Farm Security Administration / OWI Photographs – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Government photographs documenting Dust Bowl migrants and rural poverty.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What do the photographs show about who bore the costs?
- How do images shape the way we remember an era?

SOURCES 3

Franklin D. Roosevelt Presidential Library & Museum (National Archives)

PRIMARY SOURCE

FDR's fireside chats and New Deal records documenting the federal response.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did FDR explain his response to the public?
- Which New Deal program seems most consequential? Why?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

The Great Depression

1929–1939

The United States

Political

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

Voters reject Hoover's approach; FDR and the Democrats sweep the 1932 election.

SECONDARY EFFECT

A lasting expansion of the federal government's role in the economy and social welfare; a new Democratic coalition.

EVIDENCE

New Deal laws (Emergency Banking Act, Social Security Act); FDR's fireside chats; growth of federal agencies.

Economic

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

Waves of bank failures, collapsing credit, ~25% unemployment, and a ~30% drop in output.

SECONDARY EFFECT

New federal financial regulation and safety nets to prevent a recurrence.

EVIDENCE

FDIC (1933), SEC (1934), Social Security (1935); Federal Reserve data on bank suspensions and the money supply.

Social / cultural

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

Widespread poverty, homelessness ('Hoovervilles'), and breadlines; repatriation pressure on people of Mexican heritage.

SECONDARY EFFECT

Geographic / environmental

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

The Dust Bowl — drought, over-plowing, and dust storms ruin southern Plains farmland.

SECONDARY EFFECT

A strengthened labor movement and a documentary and protest culture.

EVIDENCE

FSA photographs (Dorothea Lange's Migrant Mother); Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath* (1939); WPA arts projects.

Mass 'Okie' migration to California and new federal soil-conservation policy.

The Soil Conservation Service (1935); FSA migration photos and California migrant-camp records.

Who benefited?

Depositors and investors gained lasting protections (FDIC/SEC); the elderly, unemployed, and unionized workers gained a permanent safety net; jobless workers got jobs through the WPA and CCC.

Who bore the costs?

Displaced farmers and Dust Bowl migrants; unemployed industrial and Black workers (last hired, first fired); Mexican Americans targeted by repatriation; uninsured depositors of banks that failed before 1933.

Which effect had the greatest significance? Explain with evidence.

Which pathway — political, economic, social-cultural, or geographic-environmental — produced the most lasting change in American life? Use specific evidence to defend your ranking.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your four pathways with a partner. Did you find the same immediate and secondary effects?
- Did you rank the same pathway as most lasting? Defend your ranking with evidence.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

A single economic collapse produced systemic change across government (the New Deal and a larger federal role), the economy (regulation and safety nets that endure), society and culture (labor's rise; documentary art), and the environment (the Dust Bowl and soil conservation). The costs and benefits were unevenly distributed. Push students to rank effects with evidence, not to find one 'right' answer.

Common misconceptions

- The New Deal did not fully end the Depression; WWII mobilization drove full recovery.
- The Dust Bowl was worsened by farming practices, not drought alone.
- Recovery was uneven — many groups were excluded from New Deal gains.

Vocabulary

Great Depression, New Deal, FDIC, SEC, Social Security, Dust Bowl, repatriation, WPA/CCC, laissez-faire.

Historical context

Crash Oct. 1929; ~9,000 banks suspended 1930–33; unemployment ~25% by 1933; FDR elected 1932; New Deal from 1933; Dust Bowl mid-1930s ('Black Sunday' April 14, 1935).

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Which system's change lasted longest after the Great Depression? Support your ranking with specific evidence from at least two pathways and two sources.